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WITCHES OF FATE'S EDGE

Large Cords, Curses, and the Quiet Work of Names

What a Witch Is (and Isn't)

A witch is a threshold worker one who listens to Echo (what has been), steadies the Veil (what is), and leans into Flow (what wishes to be). Witchcraft is not brute force; it is *fit*: finding where the world already wishes to move and giving it the precise nudge that sets it irrevocably in motion.

Witches there are in plenty: the Breath Wardens of Aeler, the Hedge Wrights of Viterra, the Bone Singers of Ykrul. These are good folk, mostly. Their craft is folkcraft, learned by rote and grandmother's whisper. The true witch the threshold worker learns by the Cord, by the Thorn, and by the Silent Ninth. They are the ones who know that a doorway is not an absence but a presence, that a promise is a physical weight, and that to erase a name from memory is to rewrite the stone beneath it.

The Grey Wanderer's Note: *"The hedge is what keeps the wolves from the flock. I am the one who tends the hedge."*

Section I. First Principles

subsection The Law of Named Existence

To name is to anchor. True Names fasten an Echo; forgetting frays it. Words spoken under witness reshape how a place remembers. Every curse, blessing, or bargain is a small act of creation through recognition. UnNaming (suppression, forgetting) can weaken or banish.

subsection The Concordant Layers

People, places, and vows exist as chords across Echo / Veil / Flow.

Witches feel dissonance within this chord and decide whether to *harmonize* (benediction), *redirect* (hex), or *lock in place* (binding). Wise law: do not sever, do not overrule, do not forget. Work with the existing harmony.

subsection Threshold Mechanics

All workings start at edges doorways, wakes, vows, last breaths, first light, crossroads, riverbanks. Magic is boundary law: who may pass, what must stay, and what should never meet. Thresholds are points of maximum potential for change.

subsection Element Will

Elements are wills, not mere substances. A working "argues" with a chosen will; Obligation is the debt incurred when borrowing strength from a will larger than yours.

	rule Layer	Domain
	rule Echo	Accumulation mem(past ory ac- and tions in- re- ten- peat) tion
	Veil	Preservation statecracks bound(sub- ary tle be- re- tween al- po- ity ten- breaks) tial and ac- tual
centering inewidth	Flow	Direction of (change changes will too of far) el- e- ments
	tomrule	

largepesubsection Story Weight

Stories have gravity. Meaning accrues; reality leans to fulfill it. When the table marks a complication (Story Beat), the world cashes what the scene has earned through narrative momentum.

largepesubsection The Silent Ninth

There is a missing step in the scaleacknowledged, never filled. The Ninth is absence with teeth: erasure, gaps, omissions, and the power of what is left unsaid. Manipulating the Ninth is potent and dangerous. Players never declare the Ninth; GMs may apply it only as consequence.

Largepesection II. The Five Weavers

Where the Runekeeper swears an oath and the Invoker bargains at arm's length, the witch *incorporates*. Her power is intimate, cellular, corrupting in the old sensenot rotten, but *changed*. The patron's will flows through her like milk through a jug, leaving the vessel altered.

largepesubsection Morag the Hag The Price Unspoken

Morag dwells at the crossroads where the road forks three ways. She is the grandmother who offers exactly what you need with a smile full of iron teeth. Her witches are dealmakers, oathcrafters, the ones who write contracts in milk on slate and know that every gift must be paid for, though the payment may not come due for a generation.

Law of Hidden Costs A witch of Morag can bind a promise with a red thread so fine you cannot see it until it tightens. She can ensure that a bridge stands for a century, but the cost is a child's laugh, taken in the night and kept in a jar. These witches are not evil; they are *precise*. They keep the records of consequence, and they never forget a weight.

Signature Rite The Speaking Knot (Standard, 8 XP) Bind a promise with faerie knots that tighten when broken. Breach forces 2 and marks the violator with a visible tell.

largepesubsection Inaea Mercy and the Web

Inaea is the hearthmother, the keeper of continuity, the spider at the center of the web. Where Morag demands payment, Inaea offers connection. Her witches bind families with invisible threads, ensure that oaths hold, and HEAL the cracks in the world's memory.

The Thread That Binds The witch of Inaea knows that the thread that comforts is the same that binds. She can lay a line of sanctuary across a thresholdno violence may cross it while the thread holds, but the thread remembers every blow it deflects. When it snaps, the weight comes due.

Signature Rite HearthThread Knot (Low, 4 XP) Bind yourself and one willing ally. Both gain +1 die to Aid each other this scene. If either takes Harm, the other may reduce it by 1 by suffering that same Harm instead.

largepesubsection Isoka The Serpent's Shedding

Isoka is change made manifest, the venom that burns away the old self to make room for the new. Her witches are shapeshifters in the original sense: not beasts, but souls who have learned to molt their identities like snakeskin.

The Shedding A witch of Isoka can walk into a room as a stranger and leave as your sister, the shift so seamless that reality itself accepts the change. She can cure a disease by forcing the patient to *become* someone who never had it, though the former self is lost forever.

Signature Rite The Shedding (Standard, 8 XP) +2 dice to resist a named Condition; declare a minor contingency retroactively. Mark 1 obligation.

Large subsection Ikasha She Who Sleeps in Silence

Ikasha is the patron of the threshold itself, of the space between what is said and what is meant, of the shadows that fall where no light cast them. Her witches move unseen, not by bending light but by occupying the *absence* the Ninth space, the gap between numbers, the forgotten step on the stair.

The Unspoken To call upon Ikasha is to court erasure. Her witches can remove a name from a record, from a memory, from history itself, leaving only a gap that aches like a missing tooth.

Signature Rite Touch the Umbral Veil (Low, 4 XP) Start Controlled on one Stealth roll.
Push It: The effect lasts the full scene; mark +1 Shadow.

Large subsection The Thorns of Malachai The Gift That Bites

Malachai is the Chained Angel, the Cruel Messenger, the one who answers when the desperate call. Her witches do not serve her so much as *survive* her. They are the cursed, the addicted, the broken who learned to weaponize their own fractures.

The Leashed Gift Every gift remembers how to bite. A Thorn can grant a desperate ally +2 dice on a crucial roll but the ally will owe a favor to something that collects at midnight. She can curse an enemy with a luck so foul that their own shadow trips them but the curse will spread to anyone who stands too close.

The Thorn's Bargain: A witch of Malachai does not ask "What will this cost?" She asks "Who will pay the interest?"

Signature Rite The Leashed Gift (Standard, 7 XP)

Grant a target +2 dice on their next roll. They gain a Debt. When it fills, Malachai collects: a memory, a name, or a service. The witch cannot refuse the collection only redirect it to another target.

Large section III. The Two Speeds of Witchcraft

The Long Road is ritual, threshold, price, and consequence: curses woven, bargains struck, the world's memory rewritten. It takes Significant Time (hours, days, a moon phase).

The Short Road is instinct, residue, and flicker of attention: a suddenly turned tide, a bell rung at the right moment, a thread plucked. It takes Some Time (a few heartbeats, a single action).

Large subsection Hedge Gifts

A Hedge Gift is not a spell. It is the world tilting slightly in the witch's favor because she has paid attention to the right thresholds. Hedge Gifts require no dice roll; they simply work within their limited scope.

	rule Gift	Effect	Limit
	rule Steady Hand	Remove	Once
		1 per	
		Fa- scene	
		tigue	
		from	
		your-	
		self	
		or	
		a	
		touched	
		ally	
	Salt Line	Pour	Once
		a per	
		line scene	
		of	
		salt;	
		spir-	
		its	
		test	
		Spirit+Resolve	
		3	
		to	
		cross	
	HearthSense	Ask	Once
		the per	
		GM scene	
		one	
		yes/no	
		ques-	
		tion	
		about	
		a	
		thresh-	
		old,	
		bound-	
		ary,	
		or	
		debt	
	The Unlit Candle	Extinguish	Once
		a per	
		light ses-	
		source	ation
		cre-	
		ate	
ering in	width	dim	
		light	
		or	
		dark-	
		ness	
		in	
		Near	
	Knot of Favor	Tie	Once
		a per	

§subsection Quick Workings

A Quick Working is a single action roll that relies on the witch's knowledge of thresholds, elements, and will. Its effects are limited, subtle, and always carry the risk of debt.

Procedure

tem Name the Threshold (door, tide line, wound, vow, breath) tem Choose a Layer (Echo, Veil, or Flow) and a single Tag tem GM sets Position (Controlled if you have time, Desperate if threatened) tem Roll Attribute + Skill (typically Wits + Lore, Spirit + Insight, or Presence + Sway) tem Apply Outcome Matrix

Example Effects

tem A door sticks shut (or opens) tem A candle gutters (brief darkness) tem A rope knot tightens (or loosens) tem A pursuer's footing slips (1 Fatigue) tem A whispered name is heard (or forgotten)

§subsection Full Rituals

When a witch has Significant Time (at least an hour), she may perform a Full Ritual using the five-step Threshold Working:

tem **Identify the Threshold:** Name the edge, learn its disposition tem **Choose a Witness:** A person, spirit, or Hollowed who watches tem **Name the Will:** What change you intend tem **Set the Price:** Memory, name, lock of hair, promise, blood tem **Make the Exchange:** Roll (Spirit + Lore typically), resolve, pay the price on success or partial

Full Rituals can produce permanent or longlasting effects: curses, blessings, marks, bindings, and unravellings.

§section IV. The Three Prices

Every working demands a price. Choose **one** unless a rite specifies otherwise.

§subsection Push It

Before rolling or after a Partial, you may Push to enhance the working. Choose one:

tem Mark **+1 Shadow** and gain **+1 die** tem Mark **+1 Shame** and gain **+1 Effect** tem Mark **+1 Identity Strain** and reduce DV by 1 (minimum 2)

§subsection Identity Strain Track

Identity Strain tracks cumulative erosion from self-touching magic.

Identity Strain cannot be healed by ordinary rest. It requires:

tem A Full Ritual of restoration (5, requires a witness and a personal offering) tem A significant downtime scene (confession, remembrance, or reclaiming a lost name) tem Accepting a permanent change (converting Strain into a Scar or Condition)

§section V. Promise Timers

Many workings create obligations. Represent these with a Promise⁴ or Promise⁶.

cering inewidth

rule Roll Result	Effect Cost
rule Clean Success ($S \geq DV$, $SB = 0$)	EffectNo man-cost i- fects cleanly
Success with SB ($S \geq DV$, $SB > 0$)	EffectMark work1; GM Fa- spendigue SB or for ac- com-cept pli- a ca- Con- tion di- tion
Partial ($0 < S < DV$)	EffectGain work1 par- Boon; tiallythresh- or old brieflye- mem- bers you
Miss ($S = 0$)	EffectGain fails 2 Boons; start Promise4
tomrule	

rule	Ritual	Effect	Price
rule Unravel the Wound		Restores 1 level of Harm	35+ Lock of hair, memory, a tear in a vial
	Hallow Threshold	Permanently ward a door, well, or bridge	46+ Offering (bread, salt, coin, promise)
ering inewidth			
	Unbind the Anchor	Permanently release a spirit	46+ Fill the spirit's un-finished business
tomrule			

	rule Price	What	Recovery
		It	
		Is	
	rule Shadow	Spiri	Clears
		resid	when
		GM the	
		gain	stell
		1 man-	
		SB; i-	
		may	fe
		in- or	
		tro- at	
		duces	es-
		tells	sion
		end	
	Shame	Inter	Remove
		con- by	
		se- act-	
		quenc	ing
cering in		gain	against
width		a the	
		Con-com-	
		di- pul-	
		tion	sion
		or	
		through	
		con-	
		fes-	
		sion	
	Identity	Loss	Requires
		of down-	
		self; time	
		mark	or
		1 a	
		I	den-Full
		tity	Rit-
		Strain	al
	tom	rule	

	rule	Segments	Effect
	rule 13		No me- chan- i- cal ef- fect; GM may of- fer a Devil's Bar- gain tied to iden- tity
	4		Threshold reached. At end of scene, roll Spirit + Re- solve vs 4. On suc- cess, clear 1 Strain. On fail- ure, the GM chooses: a mem- ory blurs, a bond be- comes con-
œring inewidth			

tem Mark the timer when the promise is ignored, deferred, or disrespected tem When filled, the price comes duesocially, spiritually, or narratively

Examples: sharing grief, tending a grave, protecting a hearth, reconciling rivals.

Largepesection VI. Threshold Magic (Social Interpersonal)

Threshold magic is communal, relational, and liminal. It operates where one thing becomes another: doorways, crossings, hearth edges, birthbeds, gravesides, and moments between choices.

largepesubsection Core Laws

Law of Hospitality You cannot take what you will not feed. Every working requires an offering: comfort, labor, memory, or promise.

Law of Reciprocity Binding another binds yourself to their outcome. All curses create a *Bond Condition* between caster and target.

Law of Witness Unseen workings fray. Present witness grants Position +1; casting without witness incurs +1 DV or *Lone Witch Condition* (GM choice).

largepesubsection Household Disposition

Communities and dwellings possess temperament. When entering a new settlement or threshold site, choose or roll:

tem[Hungry:] demands offerings; first working costs +1 Fatigue tem[Grieving:] magic requires memory or loss narrative tem[Fearful:] first rite is Desperate Position tem[Watching:] +1 Effect if the house is fed or soothed tem[Young:] chaotic outcomes on partials tem[Old:] weak boons but harsh backlash

Household temperament can change through care, ritual, or story.

Largepesection VII. The Craft of the Hedge (Talent)

Talent: Craft of the Hedge

Cost: 4 XP

Requirements: Lore 1+ or Survival 1+; a witch mark (tattoo, scar, or birthmark)

You have learned the small magics of thresholds and edges. You gain:

tem Two Hedge Gifts of your choice tem The ability to perform Quick Workings tem Once per session, when you fail a Quick Working roll, you may convert the Miss into a Partial Success by marking 1 Fatigue

You may learn additional Hedge Gifts for 2 XP each.

Talent: Hedge Gift of the Patron (Optional)

Cost: 6 XP

Requirements: Craft of the Hedge, Bond to a Patron

Once per session, when you would use a Hedge Gift, you may instead invoke your Patron's Imbuement. Gain +1 die to all actions tied to your Patron's domain for the scene, but mark +1 Obligation immediately. No action required.

Largepesection VIII. Curses as Architecture (GM Tool)

A witch does not curse with a word and a gesture. She *edits* the memory of the world, inserting a rule into the operating system of reality.

tshape "Until a bell is rung in your true name, lamps forget to light for you."

Anatomy of a Curse

tem **The Rule:** What changes (Veiledit, bound to a Named anchor) tem **The Timer:** Recursion6 ticks when the victim reinforces the story (hiding, refusing witness, denying the curse) tem **The Counter:** What undoes it (the bell, the name, the threshold) tem **The SB Menu:** Complications the GM can spend SB on (minor echoes, warped thresholds, layerslips, Ninth propagation)

Largepesection IX. Quick Reference

LargeKeeper's Quick Questions

tem Which layer am I touchingEcho, Veil, or Flow? tem What threshold frames the scene (door, ford, oath, mask, ledger, ferry)? tem Which Name anchorsand which must be loosened? tem Where does the Ninth already biteand who benefits if it closes?

Remember. Spend complications (Story Beats) like fate tugging the scene toward the story with the most weightthen let good witness (and player action) change which story that is. In this world, belief, craft, and consequence braid into law; witchcraft is the art of tying knots that hold without choking.

"The hedge is what keeps the wolves from the flock. I am the one who tends the hedge." fill The Grey Wanderer

rule **What**
rule Hedge Gift

Quick Working

Full Ritual

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Curse

rule lticolumn4**Identity Strain Track:** [] [] [] [] at 4, test Spirit+Resolve or lose something.
lticolumn4**Promise Timer:** [] [] [] [] / [] [] [] [] [] [] when full, price comes due.
tomrule